

The Fourth Noble Truth — The Path Leading to the End of Unsatisfactoriness

Noirin Sheahan · Noirin's Teachings · 22:46

I wanted to speak this morning on the last of these Four Noble Truths, which is the path to the end of suffering, often termed the Eightfold Path, the Noble Eightfold Path.

It's interesting, the word noble that's used in Four Noble Truths and the Noble Eightfold Path. A translation that Stephen Batchelor uses for this is ennobling. It ennobles us to deal with the difficulties of life this way. So it's an ennobling path.

The injunction with this path then is to cultivate it. So there are eight steps and each one is called right something or other: right view, right thought and so on. The word right can sometimes again bring up the judgmental mind and we can get tight around right and wrong. So again it's a translation that Stephen Batchelor developed — that the word can also refer to straightened out or untangled. And I think that gives a nicer idea that we're untangling knots.

We can often even feel that in our bodies, that various knots of tension appear here and there and everywhere. And as we sit with them as patiently as possible, they begin to just untangle, to relax a little bit. And so we're releasing tension from our bodies this way. In our minds as well — the way we say we get caught in knots of thought. So here some clarity develops around some of those knots at least. So the mind as well releasing its knots of thought. So untangling I think is a nice sense for this path. It's untangling us from the knots of delusion really.

So the first step is to do with our understanding, our view of the world. So that's the wisdom that we have been cultivating here all week. Very often we think in our culture of understanding as to why did this happen? So we're thinking in terms of the logical mind, the logical mind's way of understanding, and then that attempt to control it. If I know why, I know how not to face that again.

So the Buddha's understanding, as we know, is different. It's much more embodied, living, courageous. It's to do with refinding our wisdom again and again in this moment, rather than thinking we know it all and we can hold it up here. So we have to have the courage to drop — we can use our present level of wisdom, but not hold to it absolutely fast. We have to be able to re-question it if needed. If we feel that we're not acting wisely, we have to be able to re-question everything. So it's that willingness to let go of our present level of wisdom and let the current situation teach us again.

The Four Noble Truths — the fact that life is unsatisfying, the fact that there is a cause to this, the cause

being our rejection of life as it is, our wanting it to be our way, and the possibility of the ending of suffering when we finally surrender to that truth. So basically we create this path moment after moment for ourselves from our previous level of understanding, bringing us as wisely as possible into situations and then learning again, relearning our wisdom again. So we're creating the path all the time.

Now that then naturally transforms into an attitude. So that's the second step of the path, the right attitude or straightened out, untangled attitude, untangling attitude. So from the understanding that we're not the centre of the universe, that we have to bow really to the bigger picture again and again and learn how to come into harmony with the bigger picture, just our whole attitude towards ourselves and others begins to soften. We gradually expect a little bit less. We're not so absolutely dogmatic about my way always being right and so on.

So basically what we're developing is much more friendly, open, compassionate attitude both to ourselves and others. Not so demanding that everything go our way and more allowing of others to be just as they are, also of ourselves, the patience with this deeply embedded delusion within ourselves that doesn't fully understand the way things are. So a growing compassion and friendliness towards the world, towards ourselves. So basically I suppose that comes down to allowing rather than controlling. Seeing the way things are, finding some sort of a least resistance path around the way things are.

It's not that we won't confront what we see to be wrong. That's not the case at all. It's not a path of stupidity. It's a path of increasing wisdom. So if we see things that are wrong, we bring ourselves to the fore there and use our wisdom to try to straighten things out. But our attitude will be a lot more caring and soft than it would have been had we not trod what we have of the path already. So in that sense, solutions are actually more likely to come through because we're more open to the possibility of good in another.

If you see someone behaving badly, if you immediately put them into a total enemy situation, it means you see no good in them, no potential for good in them. And that usually brings out the worst in the other person. They react against that because it's obviously not true. We all have good in nature. So we can see — we can judge something as wrong without judging the other person as totally wrong. So therefore we can enter the situation with a much more hopeful attitude towards the other person, seeing the potential, how can they rescue themselves here? And people often respond much better in that invitation towards their own goodness.

So in general, I think then we grow more flexible. We're able to fit in better with life and appreciate ourselves and others. So we do cultivate this *mettā* meditation. We do it formally here at night, but it's also just developing naturally from our practice of *vipassanā*. It's a natural outcome of a deeper understanding of suffering, is that we naturally grow more friendly to ourselves and others.

So they're the first two steps, the untangling of our delusion into wisdom and the resulting untangling of our attitude from maybe hostility towards friendliness and openness. And the next three then are to do

with our interactions with the world, our basic moral behaviour in the world, how to bring forth our wisdom and friendliness into the world.

So there's three particular areas here that the Buddha signals out: speech, action and livelihood. And it's interesting that he puts speech first. We'd often think of action first, but in fact, he puts speech first. To a large extent, I suppose anybody who is even starting on the path, a lot of their actions may be reasonably well cleared up. We're probably not mass murderers if we're just even interested in the path. But we can still be doing a lot of unnecessary harm with our speech, just not noticing it. It's a part of ourselves that we're using so often in life, and we often just don't notice where it's become unhelpful. Whereas our actions, I think we have a little bit more judgment about what is wrong and right in terms of actions. Obviously hitting others and so on is wrong.

So anyway, in practical terms then, to really look at our speech, and he asks us to look at four particular areas of it. First of all, is it truthful? It's fairly straightforward. And also then, is it gentle or harsh? So we can tell the truth in lots of different ways. And if we're telling it with a lot of harsh, blaming anger, it probably won't be heard. So in a sense, we're better off just keeping it to ourselves and going away, sitting with the anger and then coming back and telling whatever needs to be said.

Another thing to think of then is, is it timely? In the sense that if you're telling a person something difficult, if they're already stressed out with lots of different things, they're probably not going to hear you either. And it's going to be an extra burden on them to get a bit of advice in a stressful situation. So to really think about, is this the right time for the person to hear whatever I have to say? And of course, that would go here on retreat — if it's the silence, is it the right time to break it? To really be considering that. So is our speech timely?

And the final one then is, is it purposeful? And that's a difficult one for us, I think. A lot of our chatter is fairly idle, really. And the Buddha wasn't that keen on idle chatter at all, which is a hard one to keep reflecting on.

Now, it's interesting that an awful lot of the *suttas* do start off by saying — it's often somebody coming to put a question to the Buddha and first of all there's some polite exchange, a polite and friendly exchange. So there is a certain level of — it must be idle chatter because it's not recorded — there's some level of how are you and how are things going and that. So he obviously doesn't want us to go around totally silent. There's a certain level of polite interaction needed to keep social affairs just moving and courteous and reassuring one another.

But the real danger of very idle chatter is it can move into unpleasant areas quite quickly and quite easily. We go down into our grumpy, grouse mood quite easily. And somehow in our culture, it's OK to give out about everything. We can nearly share the wound of how bad everything is. But of course, if we're doing that, we're strengthening our view that this is a horrible world and there's nothing you can do about it. So that chatter that isn't really leading us anywhere except to maybe some communal self-pity about how

bad things are, that is not helpful, as is backbiting about other people which again unfortunately idle chatter can very quickly get into. So we just have to be really careful and awake here to what is purposeful.

So anyway, those areas of speech. And then in action, the three areas: not harming — so not harming living beings, not stealing and not sexual misconduct, being careful about our sexuality, not causing hurt or harm. And of course, these can be shaded over into good as well. So not harming can become kindness. Not stealing can become generosity. And the lack of sexual misconduct, more respect for one another. Not looking at each other just as sexual gratification objects, but having respect for people, young and old, no matter what their sexual attraction is.

And then in the area of livelihood, he really just spells out wrong livelihoods. So he says one is to trade in weapons of any sort, to be making or trading in weapons, poisons as well, intoxicants. So that's a deep one to look at. If you're involved in the pub trade at all, he would say, no, that's just encouraging delusion. And the other area would be slaughter. So the whole area of butchery as well.

But of course, we can bring right livelihood around to the more positive and just see, are we giving service to others in whatever our livelihood? Are we promoting happiness here? So there are the three areas of morality and ethics that he mentions.

And there can be a confusion in our culture. We think we should really follow our own wisdom, find out for ourselves what's right and wrong and not be dictated to, as regards what kind of speech we can have, what kind of actions we can have. So that's, I suppose, a more modern approach to ethics, whereas the Buddha is definitely asking us to be much more constrained in behaviour. So I think it's a good question of why accept this constraint, just to look into it a little bit.

And certainly when I first came to Buddhism, the whole area of morality just had very little interest for me. I sensed that my morality wasn't that bad. I wasn't murdering people anyway. So I didn't have a sense that my morality was any problem area for me. All I really wanted to do was to learn how to meditate and to get enlightened.

So the Buddha likens this to actually rowing a boat without first untying it from the shore. So you can imagine that you'll be just rowing, rowing, rowing away, but you've never untied the boat. So you're getting nowhere. So learning to meditate without taking an interest in how you're putting your goodness into the world is just like that. It's not getting anywhere. So your meditation won't go anywhere until you start seeing it in the bigger context of how am I interacting with the world?

And the reason for it is fairly obviously that our behaviour affects our mind. If we're speaking carelessly to people, being harsh or whatever to people, that engenders a harsh voice in our own mind. So therefore meditation is much harder. If we're acting heedlessly, not caring for others, not really looking at them in any sensitive way, then that can produce a mental restlessness, an underlying guilt or worry, because we

are closing off to so much in life, but at the expense of any inner peace. We can close off to other people to a certain extent, but in actual fact that closes down some part of our own heart. So we're open to a lot of worry and guilt there. So again, it's hard to meditate.

And really all of this comes from the law of *kamma*. If you speak or act with good intention, then good will come of it for you in the sense that you will have the reward of a peace of mind. So your own happiness comes from good speech, good actions, those with good intentions. And the opposite is true then. If you speak or act with either carelessness or ill will, that will disturb your own mind. So it's a law of the universe, the Buddha says, that we just can't get away with. Carelessness or ill will. We can't get away with it. It's a moral law.

Now, always remembering that it's the intention. Because sometimes we act or speak with good intentions, but somehow it doesn't come out right. So it's only the intention that counts. If harm somehow comes of something we say to a person, then if we had acted with good intention in saying that, that's okay, as regards our own mind.

And you can actually experience this. You can experience *kamma* working in this way. So maybe just taking an interest — before doing something kind, like a birthday present, for example. So when you're planning to give the birthday present, see is that a happy state of mind? And usually it is. If you're giving it with generosity and the right intentions it's usually happy. I get happy thinking of somebody else becoming happy. And then as you're giving the present, is that a happy state of mind? As you're saying happy birthday and here you are, that's usually a happy state of mind. So we can just see *kamma* working there. Afterwards, when you reflect back, you think, well, that was a good thing to do. And that's, again, a happy state of mind. You just can be pleased with yourself and congratulate yourself and so on.

And the fourth way that *kamma* would work is that when we're kind to people, they usually are kind to us in return. So we tend to just begin to move more in social circles, which will help us to develop as opposed to ones that should be pulling us down all the time with backbiting and so on. So it works at that social level for us as well.

And then the fifth level which we either have to take on faith or maybe reject altogether or just have an open mind about is that in some mysterious way the universe can reward good action. So that I think — if you steal a towel from a hotel you're bound to lose a sock in the laundry. So that kind of thing. If you do something wrong, the universe will pay you back. And if you do something right, the universe will pay you back.

So that level, it's very hard to see because the actions can be separated by, who knows, years. I think they say even lifetimes. And also we do see that good fortune comes to people who are doing an awful lot of wrong. And we also see good people who get a lot of misfortune. In that sense, it's hard to put together, but it's also important to remember that the Buddha said *kamma* was only one of the laws of the universe.

So the other laws, the ones we're more familiar with, the whole law of physics, how nature works, all those kinds of things like earthquakes and tsunamis, they're just caused by physics. You know, if we're caught in one, it doesn't mean it's our bad *kamma*. It's just the law of nature working there. So he said, yeah, there's a natural law too. So not everything is your, you could say, bad *kamma*. That's a misconception.

The whole area of biology, too, is a separate law of the universe. So genetics, you know, if you have some genetic illness, that's not your bad karma. It's biology. And the whole area of psychology as well. What is our IQ? Have we good memory? Various mental illnesses. So karma is only one of those laws that actually govern how things work in the universe.

So basically, don't work backwards from *kamma*. Don't say, okay, I have this illness, so therefore it's my bad *kamma*. So it's not to work backwards, but the way we can use the law usefully is to work forwards. If I speak or act now with good intention, good will come of it. And so we can have confidence in that.

So that question, can I not decide for myself what's right and wrong? The Buddha would say definitely no there. You're heading right into trouble there. The universe has morality built into it. This law of *kamma* is a law of the universe. So it's an interesting one that we live in a moral universe.

So they're the steps of our behavior in the world. And the final steps then of the Eightfold Path are to do with our mental cultivation. So they are the right or untangled effort, mindfulness and concentration. Three steps there, effort, mindfulness and concentration.

So we're making the effort to let go of thoughts, for example, to come back to the present moment again and again and again. So that's our effort, our right effort that we've been putting in all week. An effort then cultivates mindfulness, this direct knowing of our experience, the knowing what the footstep feels like at the beginning, the middle and the end. And that in turn cultivates concentration, the ability of the mind to rest in present experience, to take it in, to see the sensations and feelings, feel how they're changing so rapidly and so on.

And that in turn deepens our wisdom. You know, might be the wisdom of *anicca* there, if you're just noticing how sensations are quickly changing and turning and slipping through your fingers and that you can't control anything. So all of that would be feeding your wisdom of the truth of the universe, these *anicca dukkha anattā*, the transience, the fact that you can't control it, the fact that it won't satisfy your actual happiness needs.

So you're back again at the beginning with a deeper understanding. So in that sense, the path develops from itself. Our efforts here at this time are bringing deeper wisdom. We bring them out into the world. That will help our meditation to be more deep. The next time we come to meditation, that will help our wisdom, which will transform our attitude and we'll bring better actions out into the world and so on. So it keeps on developing from itself and leads eventually to the complete end of all sense of stress and

suffering in life.

Thank you.

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